with clues that were far too specific to be ignored. His counterparts in the R&AW and IB shook their heads in disbelief.

The R&AW chief had always maintained that the LTTE was not behind the assassination. He stuck to his belief with ‘don’t get carried away by just one coincidental information’ to Karan. But for the SIT, the jigsaw puzzle had started falling into place. Intelligence agencies, domestic and foreign, often lived away from the ground reality. They were still choosing not to see what was right in front of their eyes. Karan did not respond to them.

In Madras, the airport police had detained a suspect who was a Sri Lankan Tamil and was trying to flee the country. They called the SIT and informed them. The same team, consisting of Raju, Kanth, Verma and Ragothaman, along with CRPF commandos, rushed to Meenambakkam.

Seeing the same officials who had earlier raided his hotel, the detained Sri Lankan heaved a sigh of relief. The SIT discovered to their disappointment that it was the same ‘Sri Lankan Tamil’ they had spoken to a few days ago. The man under suspicion said he was returning to London after finalizing his concert. The raiding team looked sheepish. But the man was upset. He registered a protest in front of everyone present and threatened Raju that he would lodge a complaint with the International Human Rights Commission for harassment upon his return to London.

Anirudhya was going through his findings so far. What emerged stronger than anything else was Haribabu’s links with the LTTE. According to intelligence gathered by Chelladurai and his team, a young man named Santhan was brought home by Haribabu in the first week of May 1991. He had left after a week. He was suspected to be an LTTE cadre. That showed Haribabu was an integral part of the Tamil Tigers. But who was Santhan? Neither the SIT nor the intelligence agencies could throw any light on him.

He compared his analysis of Haribabu with a report earlier sent in by Kaarthikeyan from Colombo. It hadn’t been easy to secure a copy, but his ‘friends’ in the SIT had helped. Kaarthikeyan’s report had mentioned